Theories of Development

PIA 3123

Dr. Francesca Chiu

f.chiu@cityu.edu.hk

Office 5331, 5/F,

Li Dak Sum Yip Yio Chin Academic Building (AC2)

Term A 2026/27

Fridays, 0900-1150

YEUNG LT-15

Department of Public and International Affairs

City University of Hong Kong

Office Hours: By appointment only

Course Description

This course explores a range of development theories, assessing their relevance in diverse contexts. Through an analysis of each development theory, the course aims to clarify its interpretation of development, target beneficiaries, and significance. Students will study the historical context, core principles, and key proponents of major development theories, facilitating critical evaluation and practical application to real-world scenarios. With an emphasis on analytical thinking and effective communication, the course equips students to evaluate the strengths and weaknesses of various theories and engage in constructive discussions. This course is suited for students interested in development studies, offering a framework to understand the theoretical underpinnings that shape international development discussions.

Assessment Methods

Format	Weight	Date
1. Participation	20%	Throughout
2. Quiz 1	30%	October 9, 2026
3. Documentary Analysis and Reflection	20%	November 20, 2026
3. Quiz 2	30%	November 27, 2026

1. Participation (20% of the final grade)

The quality of our class discussions relies on each student's preparation and active engagement. Thoroughly and critically review the assigned materials, interconnecting them with our accumulated readings and lectures. I encourage participation from every student in the class. Your participation will be evaluated throughout the semester. The class participation grade will be evaluated based on two components:

a. participation in lecture discussions
b. the calibre of feedback provided to fellow peers throughout the term.

In other words, merely attending the lecture will not result in receiving high marks; active participation in our discussions and activities are required to earn these 20 marks.

2. Quizzes (60% of the final grade)

We will have an in-class quiz during Week 6's and Week 13's lecture. The quiz will consist of short essay-style questions. It will be a closed-book quiz.

Study Strategies

The quiz is designed to assess your understanding of the main concepts and debates covered in the course, rather than your ability to memorize every single detail from the readings.

As you prepare, focus on the key concepts, arguments, and differences between the theories we have studied. You should be able to explain the main ideas in your own words and recognize how different theories would approach a development issue.

A useful way to study is to create a comparison table. For each theory or approach, consider questions such as:

- How does it understand development and underdevelopment?
- What are its main assumptions?
- What role does it give to the state, markets, international organizations, and other agents?
- What policies might follow from this approach?
- What are some of its main criticisms?
- How is it different from the other approaches we have studied?

Do not only memorize definitions. Think about how a theory could be used to interpret a real development situation. For example, if a country protects selected industries and actively directs investment toward strategic sectors, which approach might help explain this policy? Why?

Most importantly, focus on understanding the relationships between ideas. Ask yourself not only "What does this theory say?" but also "Why does it say this, how is it different from other theories, and how could I use it to understand a development policy or problem?"

Lastly, try not to leave all your studying until the day before the quiz. Study regularly.

3. Documentary Analysis and Reflection (20% of the final grade)

We will have a documentary screening in Week 12. You will watch the documentary in class and complete an individual written analysis and reflection during the lecture. The reflection will require students to identify key development issues presented in the documentary, apply relevant theories and concepts covered in the course, and critically reflect on the documentary's perspectives and implications.

A Reminder on Academic Honesty

Plagiarism will not be tolerated in any form. Refrain from copying paragraphs from printed materials or the internet. Internet sources must be cited accurately and thoroughly to allow verification. Avoid copying or purchasing papers created by others. When incorporating a direct quotation, enclose it in quotation marks and provide proper citation, including for

internet sources. Similarly, if you rephrase an argument or idea from another source, ensure appropriate citation.

To avoid plagiarism, you can use Turnitin through Canvas before the submission deadline. Instances of plagiarism, including self-plagiarism (submitting work previously used for another course), will receive zero point.

The Department of Public and International Affairs encourages students to adopt the Harvard system of referencing. In the Harvard style, a reference is made up of two parts: a short reference in the text of the document placed within parenthesis and a fuller reference given at the end of the document. Other citation styles (APA, Chicago, etc.) can be used provided only one style is used consistently and properly in the assignments. Please see the CityU library website on Citing Sources of Information at http://libguides.library.cityu.edu.hk/citing.

For additional information regarding City University of Hong Kong's rules on academic honesty, please refer to this link.

**A Note on the Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools*

Numerous AI tools are accessible online. While these tools can be advantageous for educational purposes, they also have the potential to disrupt your learning journey.

You are not allowed to use AI tools in any capacity to assist with any written assessment. Engaging in academic tasks necessitates submitting work that is genuinely your own. Using AI in an assessment includes, but is not limited to:

a. Using AI tools for research purposes
b. Incorporating ideas generated by AI
c. Employing AI translation tools

Using AI in an assessment is not considered authentic original work, regardless of the AI tools used. Your submissions undergo Turnitin checks to detect AI-generated text. Employing AI tools in your quiz and essay constitutes a form of plagiarism and will lead to zero marks and possible disciplinary actions.

Digital Etiquette

Kindly refrain from using your mobile devices during class, as this will promote a more focused and enriching discussion atmosphere. Laptops are permitted solely for taking notes during lectures and discussions.

I aim to respond to emails within 72 hours (excluding weekends). Urgent queries and requests are best avoided. Please do not send me Canvas messages.

Leave of Absence

If you are unable to attend lectures for various reasons, such as illness, hospitalisation, personal emergencies, or family issues, please reach out to me promptly. Doing so will assist in clarifying appropriate learning arrangements and support, ensuring that your absence does not unduly affect your learning and course outcomes. Should you need academic accommodations due to medical reasons affecting your participation or assignments, please contact me and provide the necessary documentation for evaluation.

Course Structure

Week 1: Introduction to International Development

Essential Readings

Kothari, U. 2019a. 'A Radical History of Development Studies: Individuals, Institutions and Ideologies'. In *A Radical History of Development Studies: Individuals, Institutions and Ideologies*, edited by Uma Kothari, 1–13. London: Zed Books.

Levitt, K.P. 2021. 'Unravelling the Canvas of History'. In *The Essential Guide to Critical Development Studies*, edited by Henry Veltmeyer and Paul Bowles, 13–20. London: Routledge.

Supplementary Readings

Farias, D. 2019. 'Outlook for the "Developing Country" Category: A Paradox of Demise and Continuity'. *Third World Quarterly* 40 (4): 668–87.

Kothari, U. 2019b. 'From Colonial Administration to Development Studies: A Postcolonial Critique of the History of Development Studies'. In *A Radical History of Development Studies: Individuals, Institutions and Ideologies*, edited by Uma Kothari, 47–66.

Week 2: The Making of Underdevelopment: Modernization and Dependency

Essential Readings

Frank, A.G. 2010. 'The Development of Underdevelopment'. In *Theory and Methodology of World Development : The Writings of Andre Gunder Frank*, edited by S. Chew and P. Lauderdale, 7–18. New York: Palgrave Macmillan.

Rostow, W.W. 1990a. 'Introduction'. In *The Stages of Economic Growth: A Non-Communist Manifesto*, 1–3. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Rostow, W.W. 1990b. 'The Five Stages of Growth- A Summary'. In *The Stages of Economic Growth: A Non-Communist Manifesto*, 4–16. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Supplementary Readings

Kvangraven, I.H. 2021. 'Beyond the Stereotype: Restating the Relevance of the Dependency Research Programme'. *Development and Change* 52 (1): 76–112.

Week 3: The Market and the State: Neoliberalism and Developmental State

Essential Readings

Biebricher, T. (2018) 'Chapter 1' in *The Political Theory of Neoliberalism*. Stanford. Stanford University Press

Carmody, P. (2019) 'Chapter 5' in *Development Theory and Practice in a Changing World*. London. Taylor & Francis.

Supplementary Readings

Harvey, D. (2007) 'Neoliberalism as Creative Destruction', *Annals of the American Academy of Political and Social Science*, 610 (1), pp. 22–44.

Wade, R.H. (2018) 'The Developmental State: Dead or Alive?', *Development and Change* 49 (2): 518–46.

Week 4: The Alternatives: Human Development and Sustainable Development

Essential Readings

Bulkeley, H. and Newell, P. (2023) 'Chapter 2' in *Governance for Whom? Equity, Justice, and the Politics of Sustainable Development*, *Governing Climate Change*. New York: Routledge.

Sen, A. (2000) 'Chapter 1' in *Development as Freedom*. Oxford: Oxford Paperbacks.

Supplementary Readings

Nussbaum, M. C. (2003) 'Capabilities as Fundamental Entitlements: Sen and Social Justice', *Feminist Economics*, 9(2–3), pp. 33–59.

United Nations (2025) *Human Development Report*. https://hdr.undp.org/content/human-development-report-2025

United Nations (2026) *The Sustainable Development Goals Report*. https://unstats.un.org/sdgs/report/2026/

Week 5: Agents of Development

Essential Readings

Li, T. M. (2007) 'Introduction' in *The Will to Improve: Governmentality, Development, and the Practice of Politics*. London: Duke University Press.

Sondarjee, M. (2021). 'Change and stability at the World Bank: inclusive practices and neoliberal technocratic rationality', *Third World Quarterly*, 42(2), pp. 348–365.

Supplementary Readings

Kothari, U. (2005) 'Authority and Expertise: The Professionalisation of International Development and the Ordering of Dissent', *Antipode*, 37(3), pp. 425–446.

Week 6: Quiz 1

/

Week 7: Politics of Aid

Essential Readings

Carothers, T. and De Gramont, D. (2013) 'Chapter 1' in *Development Aid Confronts Politics: The Almost Revolution*. Baltimore: Carnegie Endowment.

Langan, M. (2018) 'Neo-Colonialism and Donor Interventions: Western Aid Mechanisms' in *Neo-Colonialism and the Poverty of 'Development' in Africa*. Cham: Palgrave Macmillan.

Supplementary Readings

Quibria, M. G. (2014) 'Aid Effectiveness: Research, Policy and Unresolved Issues', *Development Studies Research*, 1(1), pp. 75–87.

Week 8: Gender and Development

Essential Readings

Boserup, E. (2011) 'Women's Role in Economic Development', in Visvanathan, N. et al. (eds) *The Women, Gender and Development Reader*. London: Zed Books, pp. 38–40.

Rai, S. M. (2011) 'Gender and Development: Theoretical Perspectives', in Visvanathan, N. et al. (eds) *The Women, Gender and Development Reader*. London: Zed Books, pp. 28–37.

O'Brien, R. and Williams, M. (2016) 'Gender' in *Global Political Economy: Evolution and Dynamics*, *Beyond Paradigms*. New York: Palgrave Macmillan.

Supplementary Readings

Elson, D. (1991) 'Male Bias in the Development Process: An Overview', in Elson, D. (ed.) *Male Bias in the Development Process*. New York: Manchester University Press, pp. 1–28.

Hendriks, S. (2019) 'The Role of Financial Inclusion in Driving Women's Economic Empowerment', *Development in Practice*. Taylor & Francis, 29(8), pp. 1029–1038.

UN Women (2025) The Gender Snapshot. https://www.unwomen.org/sites/default/files/2025-09/progress-on-the-sustainable-development-goals-the-gender-snapshot-2025-en.pdf

Week 9: Post-development

Essential Readings

Escobar, A. (2012) 'Introduction' in *Encountering Development: The Making and Unmaking of the Third World*. Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press.

Said, E. (2003) 'Introduction' in *Orientalism*. London: Penguin.

Supplementary Readings

Bhambra, G. K. (2014) 'Postcolonial and Decolonial Dialogues', *Postcolonial Studies*, 17(2), pp. 115–121.

Carmody, P. (2019) 'Chapter 6' in *Development Theory and Practice in a Changing World*. London. Taylor & Francis.

Week 10: Reading Week

/

Week 11: AI and the Future of International Development

Essential Readings

McMichael, P. (2017) 'Chapter 10' in *Development and Social Change: A Global Perspective*. Thousand Oaks, California: SAGE.

Schütze, P. (2024) The impacts of AI futurism: an unfiltered look at AI's true effects on the climate crisis. Ethics and Information Technology 26(23). https://doi.org/10.1007/s10676-024-09758-6

Supplementary Readings

Cameron, J. (2019) 'Journeying in Radical Development Studies: A Reflection on Thirty Years of Researching Pro-poor Development', in Kothari, U. (ed.) *A Radical History of Development Studies: Individuals, Institutions and Ideologies*. London: Zed Books, pp. 138–156.

Week 12: Documentary Screening

/

Week 13: Quiz 2

/